

EYEING WIN
Telangana CM K. Chandrashekar Rao at a campaign rally for the Munugode bypoll, Oct. 30

Photographs by MOHAMMED ALEEMUDDIN

TRS SAYS IT FOILED BJP'S 'OPERATION LOTUS', THE LATTER DUBS IT AS THE KCR REGIME'S 'DRAMA'

of senior BJP leaders also came up in the recorded conversation. The Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) special court sent the trio to judicial custody on October 29.

The next day, KCR—in his first reaction to the whole episode—took on the central government. "Telangana's self-respect is not for sale... We have more evidence to shake the Delhi *gaddi* [throne]," he declared at a poll rally in Munugode. However, the BJP has denied the allegations, even seeking a probe by the CBI or a special investigation team to reveal the truth. In a counter-attack, BJP national general secretary Tarun Chugh claims that it's KCR who has encouraged defections by rival party members in the past. "The CM orchestrated over 16 such shifts from the Congress and TDP. Some of them were even made ministers after joining the TRS," he alleges.

State BJP leaders reason that the party has little to gain by 'buying' four MLAs when the next assembly election is just a year away. The TRS has 103 MLAs in the 119-member state legislature. But political analysts point out that any defection at this time could have worked in favour of the BJP by altering the electorate's perception about the TRS's strength ahead of the bypoll. The saffron party has already won two of the four bye-elections held since 2018, and is trying hard to consolidate its position in the state ahead of the big battle in 2023.

KCR has been preparing for an even bigger battle in 2024, as he tries to stitch together an alliance to take on the BJP in the next Lok Sabha election. Any change in 'perception' would have dented his national ambitions too. "The TRS has shown that it is prepared for any dirty tricks by its opponents," says Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad. According to him, the alleged poaching bid has put the BJP on a sticky wicket, and "it will have to work very hard if it wants to do well in the 2023 assembly election". In 2018, it could win just one seat.

Meanwhile, apprehensive about any retaliatory action by the BJP-ruled Centre, the TRS government has already shored up its defence and barred the CBI from probing any case in the state without its consent. Government insiders say the decision was taken after the name of KCR's daughter K. Kavitha cropped up in the alleged Delhi liquor scam in August. ■

JHARKHAND/ SOREN

Silent Treatment

By Amitabh Srivastava

The precipitous has become the protracted in Jharkhand. And with it, the fate of the state's chief minister, Hemant Soren, continues to hang in the balance. Uncertainty looms large over his assembly membership and his chief ministership, ever since the Election Commission of India (ECI) on August 25 reportedly sent its opinion on his disqualification as an MLA to the Jharkhand Raj Bhavan in a sealed envelope. Governor Ramesh Bais, on his part, has been holding his cards close to his chest, breaking his two-month-long silence only to reveal that he had sought a "second opinion" on the issue.

Speaking to a private news channel after Diwali at his hometown Raipur, Bais did hint that a "bomb could explode any time in Jharkhand". The governor's rather casual utterance has further agitated the ruling Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM), which sees in this delay a "deliberate ploy" to destabilise the government. Moreover, Article 192 of the Indian Constitution, which deals with the disqualification of assembly members, makes no reference to a "second opinion", the JMM alleges.

Earlier, on October 15, as Soren interacted with the media in state capital Ranchi, he described Bais's silence as nothing short of a punishment: "*Jo* situation *mein aaj main hoon, Mahamahim ki* silence *mere liye* punishment *se kam nahin hai*." The CM went on to compare his situation with that of a suspect begging to be punished if found guilty.